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Leaders, Treat Resistance to Change as Valuable Data

Don’t dismiss it as kneejerk pushback. *by Ron Carucci*

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A colleague recently asked me a question about change that seemed so normal: “How do you tell the difference between legitimate concerns about a change and kneejerk resistance to it?”

At first glance, it sounds like a practical leadership question. But the more I sat with it, the more I realized it’s not actually answerable. It rests on a flawed assumption: that some resistance is legitimate and some isn’t. That assumption is exactly what gets leaders into trouble.

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When we label pushback as "kneejerk resistance," we've already made a judgment. We've decided the problem is the person, not the signal they're sending. And from there, the path is predictable: we explain harder, push faster, or eventually crack down.

But here's what years of studying and guiding organizational change have taught me: All resistance is meaningful data. As a leader, your job isn't to determine whether it's valid; it's to understand what it's telling you. No one wakes up in the morning thinking *I'm bored today. I think I'll give my leader a hard time about this change that doesn't make sense anyway.* In my experience, what we call resistance is almost always something else: fear, loss, confusion, overload, or sometimes a legitimate flaw in the change itself.

The problem is that most leaders respond to resistance at the level of behavior—missed deadlines, gossip, eye rolling, a lack of enthusiasm—without diagnosing what's underneath it. Here's why that happens and how to figure out what your team members' resistance is trying to tell you.

Why Leaders Misread Resistance

If resistance is such a rich source of insight, why do so many leaders get it wrong? Because in the moment, resistance doesn't feel like data. It feels like defiance.

When a team member questions a decision, drags their feet, or shows visible frustration, it triggers something in the leader, too. We feel challenged. Undermined. Slowed down. And under pressure to deliver results, the instinct is to move past the discomfort as quickly as possible. So, we default to interpretation instead of diagnosis.

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We tell ourselves: *They're just being difficult. They don't get it. They're not on board.* Those stories are easy, but dangerous. They collapse a complex human response into a simple character judgment. I've seen leaders fall into three traps:

1. **Personalizing the pushback.** Instead of seeing resistance as a reaction to the change, they see it as a reaction to *them*. What could be curiosity or concern gets interpreted as disrespect and disbelief.
2. **Moralizing the pushback.** Resistance becomes a question of attitude or loyalty: *Are you a team player or not?* This framing shuts down the very dialogue that could improve the change.
3. **Rushing to resolution.** Under pressure, leaders try to "solve" resistance quickly by persuading harder or escalating authority. But speed often compromises understanding.

The irony is that the more leaders push to eliminate resistance, the more they amplify it or drive it underground. People may stop speaking up, but that doesn't mean they're aligned— it just means they've decided it's no longer safe or useful to tell you what they really think.

What Resistance Is Actually Telling You

If you stop treating resistance as a problem to eliminate and start treating it as a signal to interpret, a different picture emerges. I've seen that most resistance falls into one of the following four categories, and there's often more than one at play at a time.

1. Loss: "What am I losing?"

Every change, no matter how positive, involves an ending. People may be losing authority, expertise, relationships, or even a sense of identity. A high-performing manager may no longer be the decision-maker. A tenured employee may no longer be the expert. A trusted process may disappear overnight.

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What looks like resistance is often an attempt to protect something that has mattered deeply to them. You'll see it in behaviors like:

- Defending the old way of doing things
- Undermining the new approach
- Clinging to previous decision rights
- Overemphasizing the risks of the new system

The mistake leaders make is trying to "sell" the future without acknowledging what's being left behind. Instead, you should:

- **Name the loss directly.** Don't euphemize or rush past it. Be explicit about what's changing and what people are giving up. Show respect by saying something like, "I know this changes a space you've mastered. That's a real loss, and I don't take it lightly."
- **Honor what the old way represented.** Often, people's pride and identity are tied to what's being replaced. Acknowledge the contribution of the approach before positioning what comes next.
- **Re-anchor their value in the future.** Help them see where their expertise, judgment, or relationships still matter. When people can locate themselves in the future state, they're far more willing to let go of the past.

I've observed that when people feel that what they're losing is seen and respected, they're far more willing to engage with what comes next.

2. Anxiety: "What does this mean for me?"

Uncertainty is one of the brain's most powerful stress triggers. When people don't know what the future holds, or what it means for their role, they fill in the gaps, often with worst-case scenarios. *Am I still relevant? Will I succeed in this new system? What happens if I can't?*

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When anxiety is high, people don't process information well. They may seem disengaged or resistant, but in reality, they're overwhelmed. This is where I've often seen leaders overestimate the clarity of their message. They've explained the change once, so they assume it's understood. But anxious people need repetition, consistency, and space to process. To give them that, you should:

- **Communicate consistently, not just clearly.** Repeat key messages across forums, check for understanding, and assume people need to hear things multiple times before they stick.
- **Normalize the uncertainty.** You don't need to project false certainty. In fact, acknowledging what you don't know often builds more trust than overconfidence. Say something like, "I don't have every answer yet. But I'll keep you informed, and we'll work through this together."
- **Create space for questions and processing.** Anxiety decreases when people feel heard. Make room for concerns, even if you can't resolve them immediately. Listening is itself stabilizing. That combination of honesty and steadiness does more to reduce resistance than any perfectly crafted message.

3. Lack of control: "Why is this being done to me?"

I've seen that people don't resist change as much as they resist feeling powerless or excluded in the face of it. When change is imposed without involvement, even well-designed initiatives can fail. This often shows up as:

- Passive compliance
- Minimal effort
- Retreating to old habits
- Lack of initiative or ownership

Many organizations unintentionally make this worse through what I call *faux-inclusion*: asking for input *after* key decisions have already been

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made. Employees quickly learn that their voice doesn't matter, and they stop offering it. To actually make them feel included, you should:

- **Be explicit about where people can influence the outcome.** You don't need to open up every decision, but you do need to be clear about where input matters. Ambiguity about influence erodes trust.
- **Involve people early enough to shape, not just react.** Engagement after the fact feels performative. Engagement during the process creates ownership, even if people don't get everything they want.
- **Turn participation into co-creation.** Give people real problems to solve within the change, like how to implement, adapt, or improve it. Say something like, "The direction is set. But how we make this work is something we need to figure out together."

I've seen that when people have a hand in shaping the path, they're far more likely to take responsibility for where it leads.

4. Flaws in the change: "This doesn't actually work."
Sometimes resistance isn't about emotion at all. It's about execution. Employees may see practical issues leaders have overlooked, such as:

- Timelines that aren't realistic
- Processes that don't match how work actually gets done
- Conflicts with other ongoing initiatives

But when leaders dismiss resistance too quickly, they also dismiss the possibility that the change itself needs refinement. This is where the distinction between "legitimate concern" and "resistance" becomes most dangerous because it encourages leaders to filter feedback rather than listen to it. The more useful question is: *What might this person be seeing that I'm not?* In many cases, the very people resisting the change are the ones closest to the risks that could derail it. To read employee resistance correctly, you should:

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- **Get curious before you get corrective.** Treat pushback as potential insight, not obstruction. Ask follow-up questions to understand the operational reality behind the concern.
- **Separate the signal from the delivery.** Feedback may come wrapped in frustration or bluntness, but don't let tone disqualify the content. There may be something important underneath it.
- **Be willing to adapt the plan.** The strongest change efforts evolve. Adjusting based on input doesn't weaken your leadership, it strengthens the likelihood of success.

Seen this way, resistance isn't random or irrational. It's patterned and often predictable. And it's likely pointing to something leaders need to understand or rethink. The goal is to interpret resistance accurately and respond in a way that moves people—and the change—forward.

Holding the Line

If you approach resistance this way, by listening for what's underneath it, you'll earn credibility. People may not agree with every decision, but they'll see that you've taken their concerns seriously and that you've done the work to respectfully understand before acting. And that credibility gives you something every leader eventually needs in a change effort: the right to hold the line.

But bear in mind that there's a point where resistance is no longer about processing change, but about behavior. An employee rolling their eyes once in a meeting is human. Expressing concern or frustration is expected. But consistently undermining decisions, disengaging in ways that affect others, or creating a tone that makes it harder for the team to move forward shifts from being a personal reaction to a leadership issue. People need to learn you'll honor emotion but hold the line on behavior.

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Too often, I've seen leaders swing to one of two extremes. They either crack down too early, shutting down valuable input and damaging trust, or they wait too long, hoping the behavior will resolve itself. Neither works. The leaders who navigate this well do three things:

1. **They name the behavior and its impact clearly and without judgment.** Replace vague feedback with specific observations: "I've noticed that in meetings, you've been disengaging when we discuss this change. I want to acknowledge that this isn't easy, but the pattern is affecting the team's ability to move forward." This keeps the conversation grounded in facts, not assumptions.
2. **They separate the person from the expectation.** Make it clear that it's okay to have concerns, but not to express them in ways that undermine the group: "You don't have to agree with every part of this. But I do need you to engage in a way that helps the team." This preserves dignity while reinforcing standards.
3. **They follow through consistently.** If the behavior continues, they don't escalate emotion, they escalate clarity: "If this continues, we'll need to address it more formally." Your team is always watching how you respond to moments like this. Your silence sends a signal just as clearly as your words.

If there are no consequences for behavior that undermines the change, people will draw their own conclusion that *this must not really matter.* But when leaders hold clear, consistent boundaries—*after* they've listened, engaged, and responded thoughtfully—they send a very different message: This change, this team, and how we show up for each other all matter. At its best, accountability isn't about control, but care. It's a way of saying: *I respect you enough to listen, and I respect this team enough to expect more.*

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Resistance isn't the enemy of change. In many cases, it's the beginning of better change. If you treat it as noise, you'll miss what it's trying to tell you. If you treat it as data, you can refine your approach, strengthen your people, and improve the outcome. The goal isn't to eliminate resistance; it's to understand it, so you can lead through it with both empathy and resolve.

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